

DREAM PROJECT
KCR at the construction site of the new secretariat

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HERITAGE ACTIVISTS BEMOAN THE DESTRUCTION OF THE 132-YEAR-OLD SECRETARIAT AND OPACITY IN THE DEVELOPMENT

lic utility. Built by Nizam Mahboob Ali Khan in 1885, the palace was the centre of administration of Hyderabad state; after Independence, the two-storeyed building with Corinthian columns, arches, teak-panelled interiors and an ornate staircase housed the offices of several Andhra Pradesh chief ministers. There have been several attempts to demolish it in the past, from the days N.T. Rama Rao was CM in the 1980s, points out architecture conservator Sajjad Shahid. When another such demolition plan surfaced and was challenged in court, the Andhra Pradesh High Court in 2011 directed the government to go by the advice of the Heritage Conservation Commission (HCC), which recommended its conservation. Within years, there was another attempt to pull the palace down. "An expert from Rajasthan brought at the behest of then Governor E.S.L. Narasimhan to assess the building declared the palace was strong and that it should be preserved," he says.

Apart from this, a 100-year-old stone building, which housed the electricity department offices, was also razed. Built over a century ago, it was earlier known as the Osmania Technical College.

The HCC was not reconstituted after its term expired. KCR turned a deaf ear to conservation and heritage activists too. "We have seen glistening granite and Rangoon teak being moved out and cement concrete going in," says P. Anuradha Reddy, convenor, INTACH (Indian National Trust for Art and Cultural Heritage), Telangana. On June 29, 2020, the Telangana High Court gave an order clearing the demolition of the G Block. The government demolition squad moved in soon.

As during the construction of